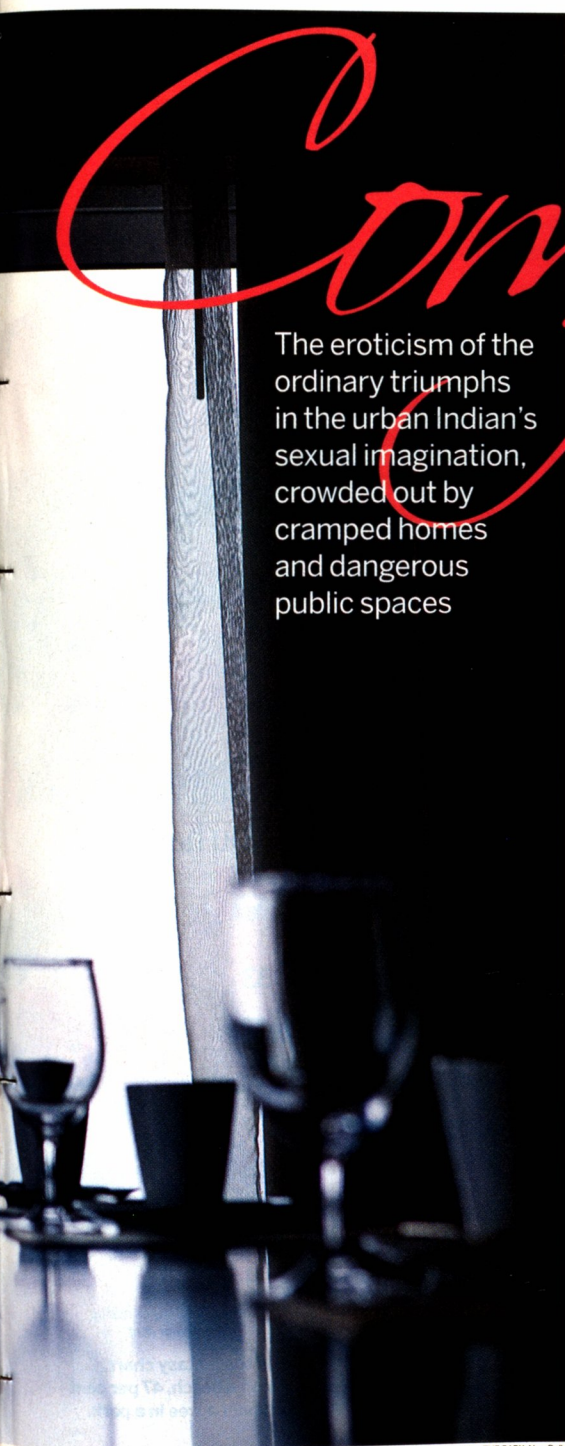




The eroticism of the ordinary triumphs in the urban Indian's sexual imagination, crowded out by cramped homes and dangerous public spaces

Comfort ZONES

By Christiane Brosius

Looking at the results of the INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey 2009, at first sight, there does not seem to be much difference between urban educated Indians and notions of fantasised sex in urban places elsewhere on this globalised planet. Particularly, through media such as cinema, we are all familiarised with erotic scenes staged at a beach, in a hotel room, a shower or a couch and, of course, a bedroom. Erotic fantasies are socialised and gender-specific, that is, men and women—whether heterosexual or homosexual—imagine erotic pleasure and intimacy in different ways, clad in different imaginaries and narratives that relate to their everyday lives. Some may be shaped by the consumption of other media, for example magazines, the Internet, cinema or television. Some may be habituated through education at home, school, college, friendships or work. A person's sexuality is by no means a private affair but rather a public good. It is generated in different contexts, depending on social status, education, economic capital, on lifestyle aspirations and a host of heterogeneous moral universes. In India, for instance, sexuality is framed by highly coded norms and values of arranged marriage, and is a property of the entire family, not just the couple. Fantasising sexuality also depends on the access to imaginary and concrete physical sites and gestures that reinforce one's 'physical being' and ability to articulate and imagine, in this case, one's sexual love life in a particular environment. For instance, the survey reveals that 56 per cent Mumbaikars fantasise about having sex on the beach and 36 per cent claim to have already done it. However, the trope of the beach is not romantic for everybody and must be located in the context of 'paradisical' love on an isolated island, the pleasure of solitude and the leisure luxury of a holiday, else, it remains a non-place, or a labour site for fishermen, a garbage bin or public toilet. Similarly, the fantasy of making love under a waterfall or in the rains might ring a bell for Bollywood aficionados for the erotics of the wet sari of the desired

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